BÓYÌ 博弈 · WEEK 6

shēng dōng jī xī

声东击西

Make a noise in the east, strike in the west.

More than 2,200 years ago, a general was ordered to cross a river and bring back a rebel king. He made a show of crossing at one ford — boats, noise, torches — and crossed somewhere else with wooden jars. Then he took the rebel's city while the rebel was still watching the wrong bank. This week you'll learn to write four characters: 声, 东, 击, 西.

Stratagem No. 6 of 36 · one story, one lesson, four characters.

本周学：声东击西 · 练字：声、东、击、西

BOATS AT ONE FORD, MEN AT ANOTHER



At Linjin: boats hull to hull, more flags than soldiers.

According to the old book Shiji, this happened more than 2,200 years ago. A general was ordered to cross a river, and bring back a rebel king.

There was one road in. He covered that road.

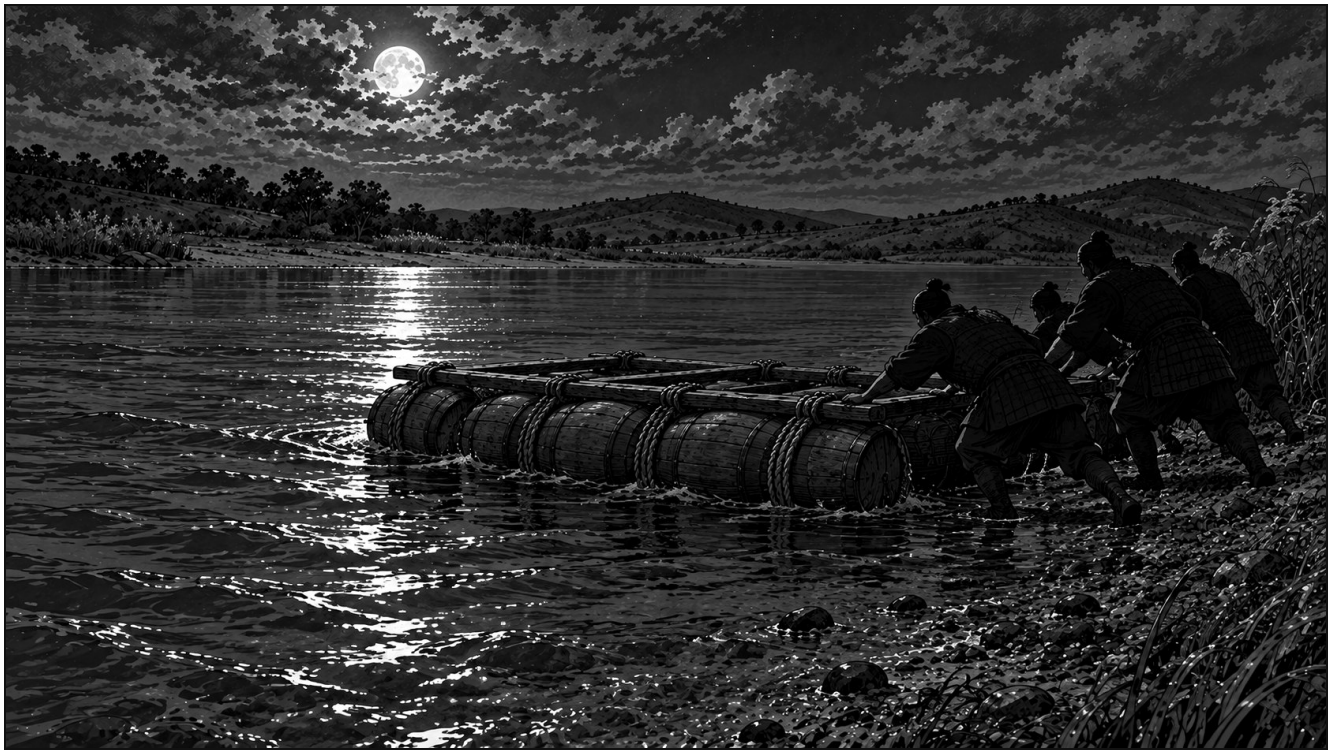
At Linjin, he lined up his boats, side by side, hull to hull. More flags than soldiers. More fires than tents.

From the far bank, it looked like a whole army, about to cross. So the king moved even more men to that bank.

Every eye was on those boats.

《史记·淮阴侯列传》

WHERE THEY LOOK IS THE WHOLE POINT



Upstream at night, the rafts go into the water. No noise, no fires.

Upstream, at Xiayang. Another crossing. No bridge. No boats. Just big wooden jars, tied together.

At night, they pushed them into the water. No noise. No fires.

They crossed, and went straight for the city behind the king's army.

The king turned his army around and ran into the men who were waiting for him.

So what he was guarding was open.

《史记·淮阴侯列传》

WHY IT WORKED

Step	Who vs who	中文 · pinyin	Result
Look there	Boats, flags, fires at Linjin	声东 shēng dōng	Every eye was on the boats
Go here	Wooden jars upstream, at night	击西 jī xī	Quiet. No lights
So	He turned, and left it open	取之 qǔ zhī	The city behind him

不骗也不藏，只选他看哪儿。 声东击西 shēng dōng jī xī

THE ORIGINAL LINES

《三十六计·第六计 声东击西》

The Thirty-Six Stratagems, No. 6 — "Make a noise in the east, strike in the west"

1

dí zhì luàn cuì bù yú

敌志乱萃，不虞，

The enemy's mind is muddled and crowded, off guard.

2

kūn xià duì shàng zhī xiàng

坤下兑上之象。

The sign: earth below, lake above.

3

lì qí bù zì zhǔ ér qǔ zhī

利其不自主而取之。

It pays to take them while they cannot decide for themselves.

Three lines, nothing more. 坤下兑上 is a hexagram in the I Ching — earth below, lake above (萃, gathering). The book is reasoning from a sign, not telling a separate story. The long commentary that follows in old editions is not part of this text.

原文只有这三句。「坤下兑上」是《易经》的萃卦（地在下、泽在上），是这一计推演的依据，不是另一个故事。后面那段按语是老版本的注释，不进原文框。

PRACTICE · 声 SHĒNG · 东 DŌNG

Follow the numbers. Write each stroke in order.

先描一遍分解格，再在田字格里写 5 遍。

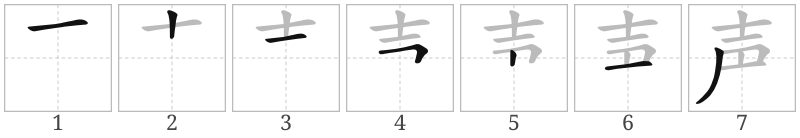


shēng

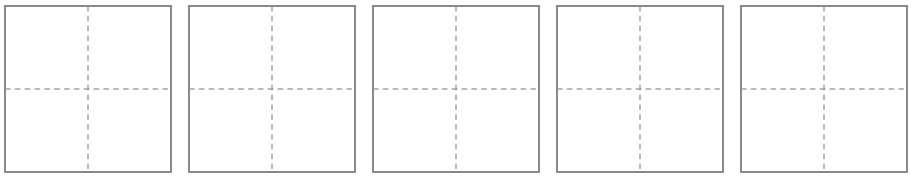
sound; noise

7 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN



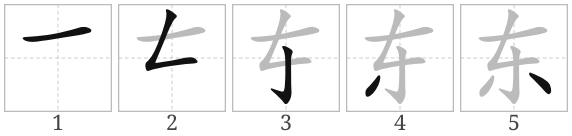


dōng

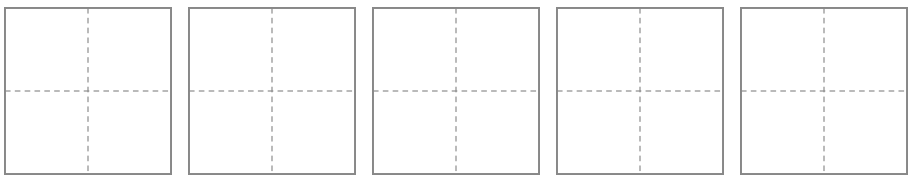
east

5 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN



PRACTICE · 击 JĪ · 西 XĪ

Same order again. Write slowly, and say the sound out loud.

写完 4 个字，再回到第 7 页连写整句。

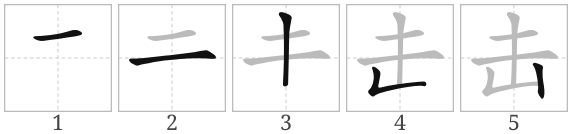


jī

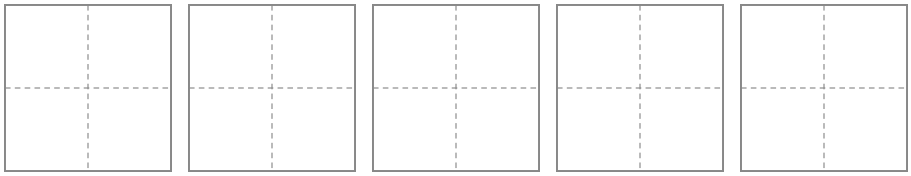
to strike

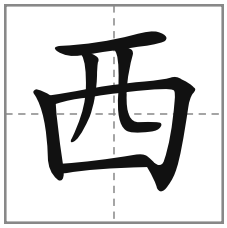
5 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN



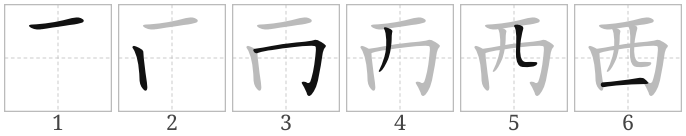


xī

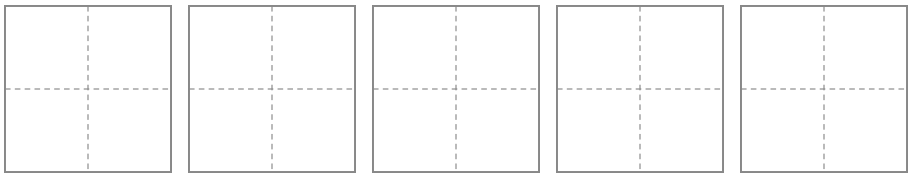
west

6 strokes

STROKE ORDER



YOUR TURN



PRACTICE · 声东击西 SHĒNG DŌNG JĪ XĪ

Trace the first row, then write the whole phrase four times. Say it out loud each time.

shēng	dōng	jī	xī
声	东	击	西

声东击西 · Make a noise in the east, strike in the west.

THREE MORE WORDS

dù hé

1 渡河

to cross a river.

dù kǒu de nà xiē chuán yí dòng méi dòng

渡口的那些船，一动没动。

The boats at the ford never moved.

The approved script says it plainly: back at the crossing, the boats had not moved. The noise was the point — the crossing happened somewhere else.

---

jiǎ zhuāng

2 假装

to pretend.

tā jiǎ zhuāng yào cóng nà lǐ guò hé

他假装要从那里过河。

He pretended he was going to cross there.

The show at the first ford is 假装 — nothing false about the boats, only about where the real crossing was.

---

kàn nǎr

3 看哪儿

where (someone) looks.

wèn tí shì tā ràng nǐ kàn nǎr

问题是他让你看哪儿。

The question is where he wants you to look.

That's the takeaway of this stratagem: watch where they want you to look.

SPOT IT · STOP IT 识破 · 防住

Back at that table: the contract is open on the last page, the pen is in your hand, and he is still talking about the color, the mats, and the free service. One signature, and the next three years are decided. You can ask one question. Most people ask the wrong one.

技术 *A technique: move the eyes*	**骗** *A lie: change the facts*
jiǎng yán sè · jiǎo diàn · miǎn fèi 讲 颜 色 · 脚 垫 · 免 费 保 养 *He talks about the color and the mats*	shù zì gǎi le 数 字 改 了 *The number was changed*
bǐ zài nǐ shǒu lǐ 笔 在 你 手 里 *The pen is in your hand*	huò huàn le 货 换 了 *The goods were swapped*
nǐ zhǐ wèn yí jù 你 只 问 一 句 *You can ask one question*	huà shì jiǎ de 话 是 假 的 *The words are false*

Two ways to move someone's eyes. One is a technique, one is a lie. That one is called fraud. So, one line: watch where they want you to look.

挪开别人的眼睛有两种：一种叫技术，一种叫骗。骗那种，叫造假。一句话：看他希望你看哪儿。

SEVEN DAYS, SEVEN QUESTIONS

Day 1 What was the loudest thing in your feed this week — and what was it covering? 声 shēng

Day 2 Which number did somebody want you to look at, so you'd skip another one? 数字 shù zì

Day 3 Where are you showing a lot of boats right now? 假装 jiǎ zhuāng

Day 4 If someone is doing this to you, which ford have you stopped watching? 渡口 dù kǒu

Day 5 Is your own move a technique or a lie? Be honest. 技术 jì shù

Day 6 What would you have to change — the facts, or only the attention? 改 gǎi

Day 7 Who is watching your east while you work in the west? 西 xī

WEEK 6 REVIEW



The one-page summary of this week. 本周一图总结。

1. In one sentence: why did the general make noise at the first ford?

2. What does 声东击西 mean, in your own words?

3. Which of this week's four characters can you write now without looking: 声, 东, 击, or 西?

4. Think of a time someone moved your eyes. What were you not watching?

Where do they want you to look this week — and what is happening on the other side of the river?

这周他们想让你看哪儿？河的另一边在发生什么？

Zhè zhōu tā men xiǎng ràng nǐ kàn nǎr? Hé de lìng yì biān zài fā shēng shén me?

BÓYÌ 博弈 · Think Like a Chinese Strategist · Week 6 · © 2026
For personal use only. Please don't share or resell.
Stroke data: Make Me a Hanzi (https://github.com/skishore/makemeahanzi), derived from Arphic Technology fonts under the Arphic Public License, via Hanzi Writer data.